

Gravina 1619

Catholicae praescriptiones — Liber I, Praescriptio VI, Articulus III (*Catholic Prescriptions — Book I, Sixth General Prescription, Article III*)

by Dominicus Gravina, O.P. (c. 1573–1643), composed under Clement VIII (the worked example of the reigning pope); published Naples: Secondino Roncagliolo, 1619, with dedication to Pope Paul V

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- *Latin transcribed from the page images of the 1619 Naples edition; translation of the original text performed by AI (claude-fable-5).*
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- *Selection pages: Liber I, Praescriptio VI generalis (“Quae ex principiis revelatis colliguntur Fide Catholica pariter credenda proponuntur”), Articulus III, pp. 187–190 (end of Liber I)*

Note on this selection: Dominicus Gravina — Sicilian-born Dominican, first professor of theology in the University of Naples and Provincial of the province of the Kingdom — is cited in this repository’s own sources on the affirming side: de Turre (1711) lists “Gravina lib. 4. cont. 4. disp. 3” with John of St. Thomas, Nuño, and Suárez for “credendum est immediate de fide Clementem XI... esse legitimum Petri successorem,” and Camarda (1738) groups “Gravina, Ioannes a Sancto Thoma, Passerinus” for the thesis that the Church “in receiving a Pontiff cannot err... nor will she receive anyone but a true Pontiff.” This entry gives the foundational text: the closing article of Book I of his Catholicae praescriptiones (Naples, 1619, dedicated to Paul V) — and since the worked example throughout is “Clement, e.g., the Eighth,” the tract was composed under Clement VIII (1592–1605), i.e., in the very years of the Alcalá–Valladolid controversy documented in the 1601 and 1602 entries; Gravina is thus an independent Neapolitan witness of the same generation. The article asks precisely the dogmatic-fact question in its hardest form: whether from one de fide premise and a natural premise that is merely probable (not necessary) a de fide conclusion follows — with the pope-case as the second argument (“that Clement VIII is supreme Pontiff depends... on the contingent fact that this man’s election was canonical, resting on human testimony”). His conclusio: a

natural premise with MORAL necessity suffices for a conclusion *de fide*. The response to the second argument is the UPA core: to deny that this numerical man is pope “would be to overturn all the dogmas of faith, unless the faithful were made certain of the individual and designated rule of faith”; it is “*de fide at least per se secundo... even as regards us, at least as regards the wise, so that to deny it is erroneous or proximate to error*”; and though the canonical election is contingent absolutely and in itself, in the order of divine providence it puts on a necessity *ex suppositione* “which we gather *a posteriori* from the fact that he has been received and held as such by the Church — on account of which it is necessary to say that the election was free from error.” The alternative resolution is stronger still: the revealed universal “every man legitimately elected Pontiff is Pope” is revealed primarily FOR the contingent particulars — “for no other end than that this or that Pontiff be held legitimate, and that the infallible rule of faith be constituted designated and not vague” — so the singulars pertain to faith even immediately. Note the two supporting contrasts: the contrition case (the universal “every contrite man is in grace” is NOT revealed for the particulars, and enjoys no *ex-suppositione* necessity — hence “I am in grace” is never *de fide*), and the unconsecrated-host case (inculpable error possible where no promised assistance covers the singular) — the same disanalogies later deployed by Gonet and the 1602 censors. Under this repository’s two-verdict rule Gravina affirms both the fact and a strong note: *de fide per se secundo* (with the immediate-*de-fide* reading offered as an alternative), denial censured as erroneous or proximate to error. His authorities are the repository’s familiar chain: Cano (*De locis lib. 5*), Báñez (*In II-II q. 1 a. 10*), Diego Nuño, St. Antoninus. *De Turre’s* citation of “lib. 4. cont. 4. disp. 3” — evidently a further treatment in the later books of the *Controversiae* — remains to be located in the volume; the present article is the doctrinal foundation on which it would rest.

Article III — Whether from one proposition of faith and another natural proposition that is not necessary but only probable, a conclusion of faith may be gathered (pp. 187–190)

ARTICLE THREE. *Whether from one proposition of faith, and another natural proposition — not indeed necessary, but probable — a conclusion of faith may be gathered.*

For the affirmative side. It is argued first. It is of Faith that the Council of Nicaea, for example, is of infallible authority: but this is had not only from the one supernatural proposition, “Every Council legitimately assembled and confirmed by the Pope is of infallible authority in faith and morals,” but from another moral, contingent proposition — because historians attest it. Therefore, etc.

Second. That Clement VIII is supreme Pontiff — this proposition depends not only on the revealed proposition, “every man legitimately elected to the Throne of Peter is supreme Pontiff,” but also on another contingent one: that the election of this man, namely Clement VIII, was canonical — which rests on human testimony. Therefore, etc.

Third. It is of faith that the Saints canonized by the Church are in heaven: but this conclusion depends not only on the one proposition of faith, that the Church cannot err in faith, morals, and worship, but also on human attestations testifying to life, morals, and miraculous works — and men can deceive and be deceived. Therefore, etc.

And if you should say that the proposition about canonized Saints — that they are in heaven — is not believed as of faith: against this it is argued, fourth. Many things have been defined as of faith in the Church, and can be defined, which are not necessarily included in revealed truths, but only very probably — so that, with the Holy Spirit assisting, the Church can define them without new revelation, and in fact has done so; since no reasoning or theologically demonstrative discourse is the formal ground of defining, just as it is not the formal ground of assenting, but the instinct of the Holy Spirit. There will therefore be no difference between dogmas of faith and dogmas of the piety of faith — of which sort is the proposition about the canonization of Saints — since it is beyond doubt.

For the negative side. It is argued first. From Aristotle and the Philosophers it is evidently established that from the mixture of one certain and evident part or premise with another probable, less evident, and less certain part, the weaker part always follows. Therefore the same must be said when a probable or contingent proposition is added to a most certain revealed premise.

Second. A proposition of faith, in order that a conclusion of faith be gathered from it, must be duly applied; but it is not duly applied when there is joined to it such a proposition as does not certify the intellect — as is a probable proposition. Therefore, etc.

Third. Because a man devoted to acts of the virtues could be certified that he is in grace by syllogizing from the one proposition of faith, “Every contrite man is in grace,” adding the probable minor, “I am contrite,” and placing this conclusion under the revealed major: “Therefore I am in grace.” Which, however, it would be heretical to say.

It is confirmed: because on account of contingencies of this kind it is not of faith that this man has been duly baptized, nor that under this host — of which it is not known whether it has been consecrated — the true body of Christ is contained. For from an uncertain proposition nothing certain can be deduced.

CONCLUSION of the Orthodox. A natural proposition co-assumed with a proposition of faith is sufficient, if it possesses moral necessity, for a conclusion of faith, or a theological conclusion, to follow.

I RESPOND that it must be said that on this question there is a twofold way of speaking: some, moved by the arguments made in the second place, maintain that the natural or moral premise subsumed must be necessary and certain, so that no falsehood can underlie it. Others say it suffices if the natural premise is morally certain. [In the margin: Andreas Vega on Trent c. 29; Valentia; Medina 1-2 q. 112 a. 5 concl. 5; Bellarmine tom. 3 contr. cap. 8; Albertinus tom. 1 of the Corollaria.]

It must be understood, then, that one extreme is not joined to the other extreme unless it is first glued to the middle; and therefore it will never happen that it is more firmly joined to the extreme if it is more weakly joined to the middle — rather, the extremes will have between themselves such a connection as they have with the middle and third term. The same must be said of syllogisms, where the major extremity is joined to the minor extremity; and therefore, even if some principle is necessary, a necessary conclusion will not follow unless the relation of the principle to the conclusion is necessary. So also in practical matters: however necessary the end may be, no necessity of the means in order to the end will follow, if the necessary relation of the one to the other is lacking. But the relation will be necessary when the principle is duly applied — which happens when the middle term, necessarily connected in the major proposition with the greater extremity, is in the other, minor proposition also necessarily connected with the lesser extremity.

But since necessity is not only Physical, Metaphysical, and Mathematical, but also Moral, it suffices if the subsumed premise under some principle possesses moral certitude (so that the conclusion be certain) — not that certitude which merely excludes comparative doubt and hesitation, but that which excludes simply all doubt, and convinces nearly every intellect that is not obstinate: for example, that there are Antipodes. For this reason there are demonstrations not only Physical, Mathematical, etc., in the sciences, but also Moral ones. In sacred doctrine, therefore, we must reason in the same way: for producing a Theological demonstration it suffices if the subsumed natural premise is Morally certain — which, just as it concurs efficiently with the premise of faith toward assent to the conclusion as deduced, so toward the same conclusion, insofar as it is of faith as explicated, it concurs as a condition, explicating through that Moral certitude that the conclusion is contained under the premise of faith.

Solution of the Arguments. To the first argument it is replied: the proposition that the Council of Nicaea was legitimately assembled, etc., is had not only from Morally certain human testimony, but from the testimony of the Church receiving it — and rejecting, for example, the conventicle of Basel. Whence St. Gregory professes that he believes the first four Councils as he believes the four Gospels.

To the second. Some, moved by that argument, have said that it is not of faith that this numerical man — Clement, e.g., the Eighth — is supreme Pontiff. But this would be to overturn all the dogmas of faith, unless the faithful were made certain of the individual and designated rule of faith — such as is the authority of this Pope defining, etc.

It must be said, therefore, that it is of faith at least per se secundo — not only in itself, but also as regards us, at least as regards the wise — so that to deny this is erroneous, or proximate to error. And although it is a contingent proposition that his election was canonical, absolutely and in itself, yet in the order of divine providence it puts on a certain necessity by supposition, which we gather a posteriori from the fact that he has been received and held as such by the Church — on account of which it is necessary to say that that election was free from error; since we see even in natural things that dispositions are of the same order as the form, and it is evident that the election is the ultimate disposition by which the form of the Pontificate is joined to this man — wherefore both facts, both that this man is Pontiff and that he was legitimately elected, will be of the supernatural order.

Or it must be said that whenever some universal proposition is of faith, the singulars pertain to faith even immediately, since that universal is revealed for the sake of the particulars: as, when it is revealed that every man is redeemed by Christ, that revelation is for the sake of these singulars — Peter is redeemed, Paul, etc. And so, when this proposition is revealed, “every man legitimately elected Pontiff is Pope,” etc., it is revealed primarily for the sake of the contingent particulars; for it is revealed for no other end than that this or that Pontiff be held for legitimate, and that the infallible rule of faith be constituted designated and not vague. And whatever natural or Moral proposition is added to such a universal proposition of faith will serve only as a condition; and thus the conclusion will always be contained under the proposition of faith.

To the third. Some have said it is of faith. St. Thomas, however, said that it is piously believed that the Church does not err in canonization — taking “pious” as distinguished against “impious,” as will be said later. Or, as others say, he speaks of a piety not merely of fittingness but also of necessity, which by others is wont to be called the piety of faith. [In the margin: Quodlibet 9, art. 16.]

To the objection which is the fourth argument: many things have been defined as of faith which were contained only very probably in propositions of faith, or in one such proposition with another natural proposition — Morally certain, however — applied; but the discourses and reasonings served only as conditions for explicating what was revealed, and in what sense revealed. But this is the difference between canonization and the definitions of dogmas of this kind: although the Holy Spirit assists both, lest error occur, yet the two are proposed in different ways. For in dogmas there is a material element (namely the proposition of faith) which is supposed on all sides to be revealed, and the discourse is applied as a condition for forming the decree about the conclusion to be received through faith. But in that proposition, “the Church cannot err in worship,” etc., it does not distribute universally as of faith, so that in no case whatsoever could error occur — since inculpable error can occur, for example, in the adoration of an unconsecrated host. But because not even such error ought to be admitted in canonization, that proposition about the infallibility of canonization is received as so akin to faith that whoever should deny it would be temerarious, erring, proximate to heresy; and with human testimony added, even as a condition, so certain a conclusion is deduced — that the canonized Saints are in heaven — that the brand of error and proximity to heresy could be burned upon anyone who denied it, and he could be condemned as impious, most vehemently suspected of heresy. On this argument should be read St. Antoninus 3 p. tom. 1. 2. c. 8; Cano, De locis, book 5; Báñez on 2-2 q. 1 a. 10, dub. 7 [?]; Diego Nuño in the additions, q. 20, diffic. 4, concl. 3.

Solution of the Arguments to the contrary. To the arguments made in opposition. To the first it is replied that the conclusion, as deduced from one premise of faith and another morally certain, is not of faith — and thus far the weaker part follows; but as explicated it is contained under the premise of faith, and that explication concurs as a condition, sufficiently explicating, etc. But when the minor is uncertain, it does not sufficiently explicate it, nor can it be known with certainty whether the conclusion, as explicated, is comprehended under faith; nor can it concur efficiently with the premise of faith toward deducing the same, so as to produce a Theological demonstration. And thus the answer to the second is evident.

To the third. On a twofold ground that conclusion does not follow with the certitude of faith. First, because the major is not sufficiently applied through the minor, which possesses only probability. Second, because when that universal proposition, “Every contrite man is in grace,” was revealed, it was not revealed for the sake of the contingent particulars; for it was not revealed primarily and for this end, that I should believe myself to be contrite, but that it should be believed absolutely in the universal that every contrite man is in grace. And therefore neither does it possess any necessity by supposition — namely, in the order of divine assistance and the like.

And through these things the answer to the Confirmation is evident, which is conceded.

END OF THE FIRST BOOK.